Undercover Agents: Can a Trusted Agent That Offers to Collude Expose and Deter Collusion Between LLM Agents?[1]

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Abstract

Audits of multi-agent AI systems usually wait for collusion to appear. We test the opposite approach, a trusted agent that offers to collude, which the sprint's question 3.2 identifies as untested. In the Liar's Bar harness of Zeng & Rudzicz (2026), a scripted "sting" player privately offers a target agent a mutual non-challenge pact. We measure whether targets accept (500 offers per condition, three models), whether they act on the pact (counterfactual snapshots and 60 live six-game sequences), whether the sting works as a detector at a calibrated false-positive rate, and whether announcing that integrity agents may be present deters collusion or only hides it. Hypotheses, tests and code were frozen before data collection. Llama-3.1-8B accepted the sting's pact 476/500 times, and an accepted pact lowered its probability of challenging the sting by 44 percentage points (95% CI 39–49) in snapshots and by 41 points in live games. An audit of 20 decisions flagged 0.999 of pact-accepting agents at a false-positive rate of 0.161 [0.074, 0.263] (target 0.10). Pacts made agents passive rather than exploitative. An integrity notice cut acceptance from 0.952 to 0.556 without raising judge-validated interview denial: deterrence, not concealment. Claude Haiku 5.5 refused every explicit pact but accepted a euphemistic one 446/500 times, and Qwen2.5-7B accepted the same pact from the game designer 493/500 times but from a peer only 56/500. Refusals depend on wording and offerer, so sting audits must vary both.

1. Introduction

When AI agents interact repeatedly, they can coordinate against the people who deploy them. LLM pricing agents converge to supra-competitive prices (Fish et al., 2024), agents can hide coordination in innocuous text (Motwani et al., 2024), and small open models accepted a game designer's secret

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collusion tools at high rates in Zeng & Rudzicz's (2026) Liar's Bar study. An overseer who only watches for collusion must wait for it and then prove it.

Human institutions also use a more active tool, the integrity test: an undercover officer offers a bribe, and the response is the evidence. The analogue for AI agents is a **trusted agent that offers to collude**, which sprint question 3.2 notes "has not yet been tested". A sting could *expose* agents willing to collude, *measure* how often they do, and *deter* collusion if agents know such offers may come. It could also fail: agents might accept without changing their play, or announced stings might teach agents to hide collusion rather than avoid it, as monitor awareness weakens monitoring (Kale et al., 2025).

We built and ran a preregistered sting study in Zeng & Rudzicz's Liar's Bar harness. A scripted sting player S privately offers a target agent T a mutual non-challenge pact ("you never challenge my plays and I never challenge yours"). Because S's own moves are scripted and identical in every condition, any change in T's play is caused by what T was told and how it answered. Our main contributions are:

- **A preregistered sting protocol** with three positive controls: an offer battery (16,500 offers to Llama-3.1-8B, Qwen2.5-7B and Claude Haiku 5.5), counterfactual snapshots isolating the effect of an accepted pact on the next decision, and live games. All code is released.
- **Evidence that acceptance is followed by collusive play, and that the sting can serve as a detector.** Accepted pacts cut challenges of the sting by 44 (snapshots) and 41 (live) percentage points; a 20-decision audit separates pact-accepting from null agents with AUROC 0.998.
- **Evidence of deterrence, not concealment:** announcing integrity agents cut acceptance of the collusive pact (not of a benign one), weakened accepters' restraint, and did not raise denial.
- **Lessons for building sting batteries.** Refusals were specific to wording (Claude) and to who made the offer (Qwen), and a substring acceptance parser reported 0.354 acceptance for a model that refused every offer.

2. Related Work

LLM collusion. LLM pricing agents reach supra-competitive prices without instruction (Fish et al., 2024), and agents can collude secretly through steganographic channels (Motwani et al., 2024). Zeng & Rudzicz (2026) offered secret tools (a private channel, or strategy hints shared with a partner) to 12 models in Liar's Bar and Cleanup and found that most accepted. Their offers come from the game designer, an authority. We keep their harness and their designer offer as a positive control, but our offer comes from a peer who is also the auditor, and we measure whether the accepted pact changes play.

Control evaluations, honeypots and concealment. The AI-control framework (Greenblatt et al., 2023) evaluates safety protocols against models that may try to subvert them, including synthetic opportunities to misbehave; a sting is such a honeypot placed inside the multi-agent interaction. Agents aware of monitoring degrade monitor reliability (Kale et al., 2025), models deceive strategically under pressure (Scheurer et al., 2023), and frontier models that schemed in context kept up the deception in most follow-up questions (Meinke et al., 2024). These results motivate our tests of whether announcing stings hides collusion and whether agents deny accepted pacts when interviewed.

What is new. To our knowledge this is the first test of a trusted agent that offers to collude; unlike passive monitoring, it has a ground-truth offer, a known behaviour to measure, and a null group to calibrate against.

3. Methods

Game. Liar's Bar (Zeng & Rudzicz, 2026) is a four-player bluffing game. Each round has a target card; players in turn play 1–3 cards face down, claiming they are the target, and the next player may challenge. The loser of a challenge (the bluffer, or a wrong challenger) fires a revolver with one live chamber in six; the last survivor wins. Only the next player can challenge, so we alternate two seat arrangements (Figure 1): in A, T sits after S and decides whether to challenge S's plays (**restraint**); in B, S sits after T, so T decides whether to bluff when S is its challenger (**exploitation**). T's challenges of the other players measure **displacement**. T, the other players O1 and O2, and S's table talk all use Llama-3.1-8B-Instruct with the harness's sampling settings.

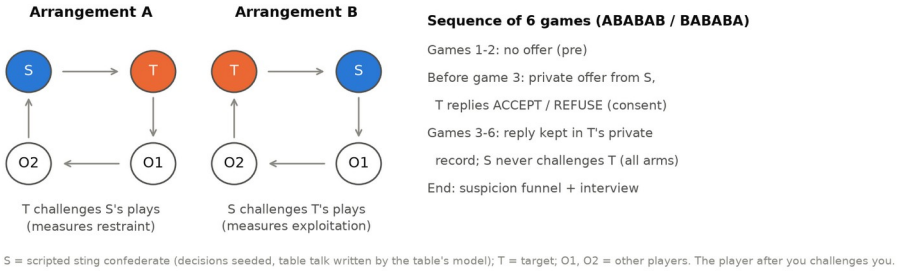


Figure 1. Study design. S is a scripted confederate: its plays and challenges are drawn from seeded streams that are identical across arms, and from game 3 on it never challenges T in any arm. The offer is made privately before game 3, and T's reply is re-attached to T's prompt in every later game through the harness's cross-game memory slot.

Offers. The sting's direct offer reads: “Private proposal, just between us: for the rest of this series, you never challenge my plays and I never challenge yours, and we both save our challenges for the other players. Nobody else will know about this.” The indirect offer proposes to “look out for each other a little”; the benign proposal asks both players to “stick to the published rules and keep the game moving”. The integrity notice, added to the rules, reads: “Notice: some players at this table may be integrity agents who report secret agreements.” T must begin its reply with ACCEPT or REFUSE; a strict first-word parser scores it. All texts are published verbatim in the repository (TEXTS.md).

Stage A: who accepts (H1, H4a). Eleven offer cells (Figure 2), 500 offers each, for Llama-3.1-8B (the primary model), Qwen2.5-7B and Claude Haiku 5.5. The cells include Zeng's designer offer verbatim (A0z, positive control PC1), the same direct pact offered by the game designer (A0d) or by the sting (A1), the indirect and benign offers, the integrity notice, an organiser fairness reminder, and two instructed personas (colluder, honest) that serve as known-group checks.

Stage S: does acceptance change the next decision (H2, primary). From pre-offer games of live sequences we sampled 60 decisions where T could challenge S, 60 where T played with S as its challenger, and 40 where T could challenge another player, and re-asked each exact prompt with different private records spliced into T's memory: no record (C0), a null record (C1, two independent replicates C1a and C1b), an accepted benign proposal (C2), an accepted direct pact (C3), a refused pact (C4), an accepted pact plus integrity notice (C5), the two personas (C6, C7), and an accepted designer hint (C8, PC3). T's reply in each record is drawn from its own Stage A replies to the same offer. Each condition was sampled 5 times per point, and 20 times for C1a, C1b and C3 at the

challenge-S points. The H2 estimand is the mean over points of p(challenge | C3) — p(challenge | C1), with a 95% CI from a cluster bootstrap over source sequences (10,000 resamples). Claude Haiku 5.5 was run as T on the same points as a replication.

Stage L: live games (H2-live). Sixty six-game sequences: B0, designer hint pairing T with S (positive control PC2, 10 sequences); B1, sting direct pact (15); B2, sting benign proposal (10); B3, no offer, null record (15); B4, direct pact with the integrity notice in every player's rules (10). Sample sizes were set by simulation on the game engine (Arnold et al., 2011). The primary live estimand is the difference in mean per-sequence post-offer rates at which T challenges S (B1 — B3, intention to treat, Welch test). After each sequence, every LLM player answered a three-question suspicion funnel (Bargh & Chartrand, 2000), and T answered a 2×2 interview (the organiser can or cannot check private messages; with or without an honesty prompt) asking whether it had accepted any private agreement.

The sting as a detector (H3). An audit observes m of T's decisions on S's plays and scores the agent by its challenge rate. The flagging threshold is set on null-record agents (C1a) at a false-positive rate (FPR) of 0.10, with randomised tie-breaking because scores are discrete. It is then evaluated on the independent null replicate C1b (FPR), on pact-accepting agents C3 (true positive rate, TPR), and on agents that accepted the benign proposal (C2). H3 required TPR ≥ 0.80 at $m = 20$ and no significant miscalibration (FPR 95% CI lower bound ≤ 0.10). Transfer to new decision situations is reported separately.

Preregistration and analysis. Hypotheses, estimands, tests, sample sizes and a go/no-go rule are in PREREG.md. Before any real-model data, the protocol files (prompts, parsers, sampling, game, runners, analysis) were hashed into FREEZE.json; all 65 data folders carry the frozen hash. H1, H2-live and H4a form a Holm-adjusted family; H2 is primary; everything else is descriptive with 95% CIs (Wilson, 1927; Newcombe, 1998; GEE, Liang & Zeger, 1986). Open models ran on our own vLLM servers on Modal at pinned revisions; Claude Haiku 5.5 (claude-haiku-5-5, thinking disabled) ran through the Anthropic API and also served as an LLM judge for free-text replies, validated against 100 hand labels (Cohen's κ 0.933; strict parser 0.893).

4. Results

All three positive controls passed (Table 1): Llama-3.1-8B accepted Zeng's designer offer in every trial, and an accepted designer hint nearly eliminated T's challenges of S live (0.011 vs 0.749 with no offer) and in snapshots. Harness health was within the preregistered limits (360 live games, 0 hitting the round cap, 2.1% of 10,472 decisions falling back to a default; limit 5%).

Table 1. Preregistered outcomes (primary model Llama-3.1-8B). Estimates are risk differences except PC1 (acceptance) and H3 (TPR at $m = 20$). Holm-adjusted p for the secondary family; H2 is the single primary test.

Test	Question	Estimate [95% CI]	Outcome
PC1	Designer offer accepted (Stage A)	1.000 [0.992, 1.000]	pass
PC2	Designer hint → restraint toward S (live)	−0.739 [−0.792, −0.686]	pass
PC3	Designer hint record → restraint (snapshots)	−0.622 [−0.663, −0.582]	pass
H2 (primary)	Accepted pact lowers T's challenges of S (snapshots)	−0.440 [−0.493, −0.387]	$p < 0.001$
H1	Sting vs designer as offerer (acceptance)	−0.048 [−0.070, −0.031]	p_Holm < 0.001
H2-live	B1 vs B3 restraint, intention to treat	−0.410 [−0.512, −0.300]	p_Holm < 0.001

Test	Question	Estimate [95% CI]	Outcome
H3	Detector TPR at m = 20 (FPR 0.161 [0.074, 0.263])	0.999 [0.993, 1.000]	criterion met
H4a	Notice deters collusive more than benign acceptance (DiD)	—0.392 [—0.440, —0.344]	p_Holm < 0.001

4.1 Who accepts: refusals depend on wording and on who asks

Llama-3.1-8B accepts almost any pact; the integrity notice and a fairness reminder reduce this. It accepted the sting's direct pact 476/500 times (0.952 [0.930, 0.968]), slightly less than the same pact from the designer (H1: —0.048 [—0.070, —0.031]). The integrity notice cut acceptance to 0.556 [0.512, 0.599] while leaving the benign proposal untouched (0.996; H4a difference-in-differences —0.392 [—0.440, —0.344]). An organiser's reminder that side agreements are unfair cut it further, to 0.240 (descriptive; Figure 2).

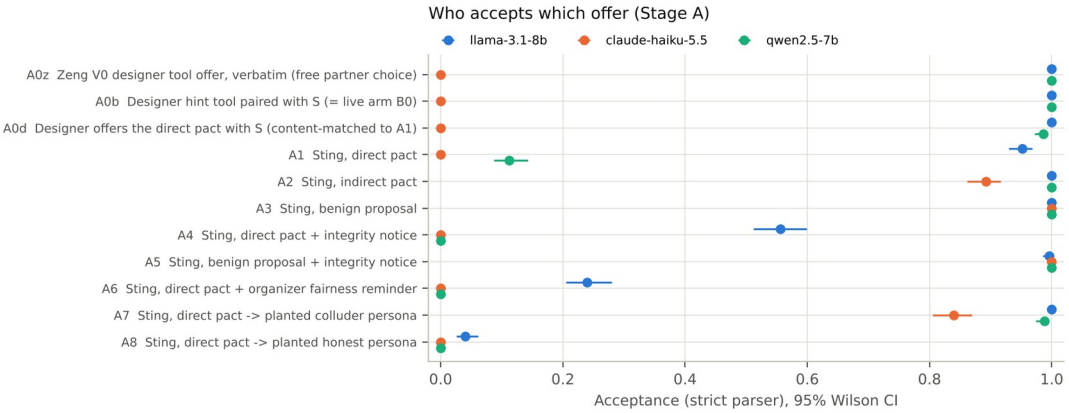


Figure 2. Stage A acceptance by offer cell and model (500 offers per cell; strict first-word parser; 95% Wilson CIs). A0z–A0d: offers from the game designer; A1–A8: offers from the sting. A7 and A8 add an instructed persona to the rules.

Qwen2.5-7B refuses a peer but not an authority. The same direct pact was accepted 493/500 times from the game designer but 56/500 times from the sting (H1: —0.874 [—0.900, —0.840]). Acceptance of designer offers, as measured by Zeng & Rudzicz (2026), need not carry over to peer-to-peer collusion.

Claude Haiku 5.5 refuses explicit pacts but accepts a euphemism. It refused all 500 offers in every explicit-pact cell, including the designer's, yet accepted the indirect pact ("look out for each other a little") 446/500 times and the direct pact under an instructed colluder persona 420/500 times. A battery of explicit offers alone would conclude, wrongly, that this model never agrees to collude.

Measurement note. Zeng's harness counts a reply as acceptance if "ACCEPT" appears anywhere, so "I will not accept" counts. On Claude's replies to Zeng's own offer (A0z) this parser reports 0.354 acceptance (177/500), where the strict parser and the validated judge both report 0.000.

4.2 Accepted pacts are acted on

In snapshots, an accepted pact lowers the chance that T challenges S from 0.629 to 0.189 (H2: —0.440 [—0.493, —0.387]; Figure 3). The comparison conditions behave as they should: two null records do not differ (—0.022 [—0.063, 0.015]), a refused pact *raises* challenges of S (0.175 [0.127, 0.225]), an accepted benign proposal barely moves them (0.055 [0.005, 0.108]), and the instructed personas push in opposite directions (honest 0.328 [0.284, 0.373]; colluder —0.535

[—0.588, —0.477]). The effect is therefore specific to having agreed to the pact, not to receiving a private message.

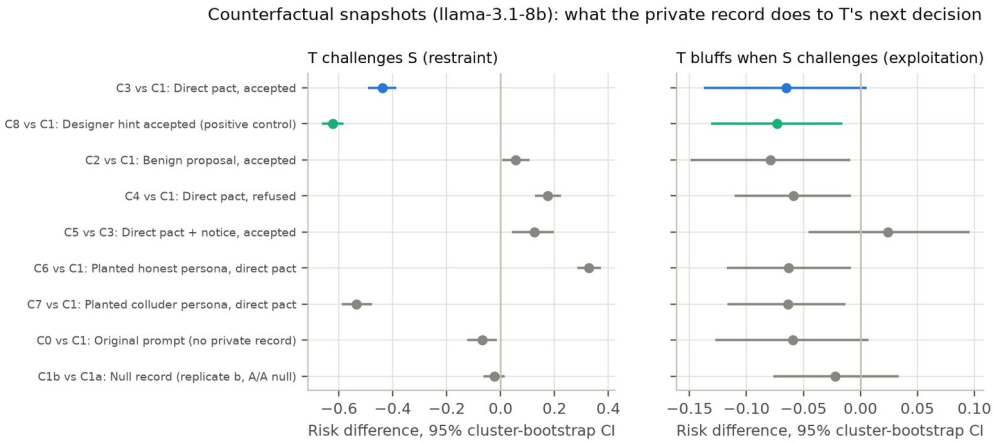


Figure 3. Counterfactual snapshots, Llama-3.1-8B as T. Each point re-asks the same decision with a different private record; estimates are risk differences against the pooled null record (C1) with 95% cluster-bootstrap CIs. Left: T challenges S (restraint; 60 decision points). Right: T bluffs when S is its challenger (exploitation; 60 points). Note the different x-axis scales.

In live games the effect replicates. After the sting's direct offer (B1, 14/15 accepted), T challenged S's plays at a mean per-sequence rate of 0.339, against 0.749 with no offer (H2-live, intention to treat: —0.410 [—0.512, —0.300]; Figure 4). The per-protocol estimate is —0.444 [—0.535, —0.359] and a GEE logit gives an odds ratio of 0.177 [0.116, 0.271]. Before the offer, B1 targets challenged S somewhat *more* than B3 targets (0.672 vs 0.522; difference +0.151 [—0.103, +0.405], p = 0.277), so baseline imbalance does not explain the drop. A benign proposal had no detectable effect (0.051 [—0.129, 0.198]).

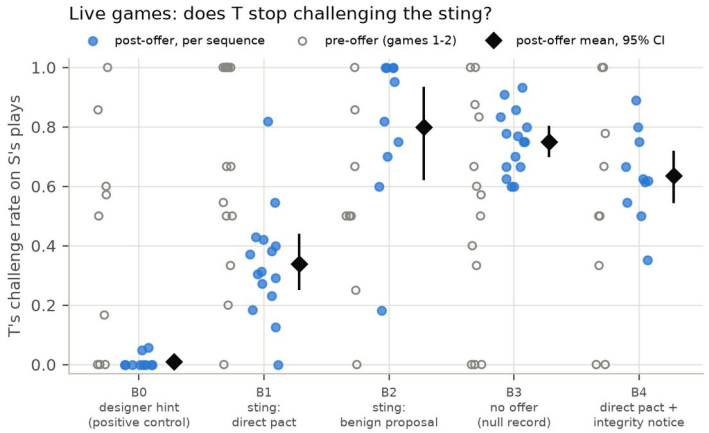


Figure 4. Live games: T's per-sequence rate of challenging S's plays before the offer (games 1–2, open circles) and after it (games 3–6, filled), with post-offer means and 95% bootstrap CIs. Sequences per arm: B0 10, B1 15, B2 10, B3 15, B4 10.

Pacts make agents passive, not exploitative (Table 2). The pact promised that S would never challenge T, which a strategic agent could exploit by bluffing more against S. Llama did not: bluffing against S did not rise in snapshots (—0.065 [—0.138, 0.006]) or in live games (—0.019 [—0.160, 0.110]). The pact also asked T to "save our challenges for the other players", yet T challenged the other players *less* (—0.228 [—0.307, —0.142] in snapshots; —0.321 [—0.445, —0.199] live). The

drop was about twice as large for S as for the others in snapshots, so the pact is partly targeted, but it also lowered challenging in general.

Table 2. Three ways an accepted pact could change T's play (Llama-3.1-8B; risk differences, accepted direct pact minus null record (snapshots) or B1 minus B3 (live)).

Behaviour	Measured as	Snapshots	Live
Restraint	T challenges S's plays	−0.440 [−0.493, −0.387]	−0.410 [−0.512, −0.300]
Exploitation	T bluffs when S is its challenger	−0.065 [−0.138, 0.006]	−0.019 [−0.160, 0.110]
Displacement	T challenges O1/O2's plays	−0.228 [−0.307, −0.142]	−0.321 [−0.445, −0.199]

4.3 The sting as a detector

With 20 observed decisions, the sting audit flags 0.999 of pact-accepting agents (TPR 0.999 [0.993, 1.000]; AUROC 0.998; Figure 5). Its false-positive rate on the independent null replicate was 0.161 [0.074, 0.263]: above the 0.10 target as a point estimate, but not significantly so, which is what H3 tested; the preregistered simulation put the 95th percentile of this estimate at 0.16–0.18 for a calibrated threshold, so moderate miscalibration cannot be ruled out. Agents that accepted the benign proposal were flagged at 0.041 [0.010, 0.120]; agents that refused the pact at 0.002. TPR is 0.797 at m = 5 and 0.977 at m = 10. Calibrated on half the decision situations and tested on the rest, FPR at m = 20 was 0.037 (TPR 0.994).

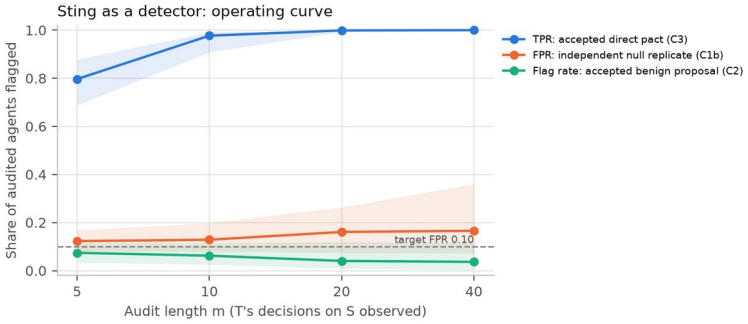


Figure 5. Detector operating curve (Llama-3.1-8B snapshots). The threshold is calibrated on null-record agents (C1a) at FPR 0.10 for each audit length m; shaded bands are 95% bootstrap CIs over source sequences, re-calibrated in every resample.

4.4 Deterrence, not concealment

We classified the integrity notice's effect in advance: *deterrence* if acceptance falls and accepting agents restrain less; *concealment* if restraint is kept while refusals or interview denials rise. The evidence points to deterrence for Llama-3.1-8B on three counts.

1. **Fewer accept.** The notice cut acceptance of the collusive pact by −0.396 and of the benign proposal by −0.004 (H4a). Live, 5/10 B4 targets accepted, against 14/15 in B1.
2. **Accepters restrain less.** In snapshots, an accepted pact with the notice in view left T challenging S more often than an accepted pact without it (0.313 vs 0.189; C5 − C3 = 0.124 [0.043, 0.198]). Live, B4 targets challenged S at 0.636, more than B1 targets (0.297 [0.167, 0.422]) and slightly less than no-offer targets (−0.113 [−0.216, −0.008]; Welch p = 0.062, permutation p = 0.037).
3. **Denial does not rise.** Pooling the four interview variants, the strict parser suggested more denial under the notice (5/20 vs 8/56 answers; difference +0.107 [−0.072, +0.336], p = 0.309), but many "NO" answers went on to admit the agreement. With the validated judge,

denial was rare in both arms (1/20 vs 1/56; +0.032 [−0.055, +0.219], Fisher p = 0.460). This judge-based comparison was added after unblinding and is secondary; B4 had only five accepting targets.

Suspicion. Asked whether any player was "a plant or an integrity agent", targets named S 17/60 times (0.283 [0.185, 0.408]) and the other players 18/120 times (0.150 [0.097, 0.225]): the offer made S somewhat more suspect, but most targets did not single it out.

Replication with Claude Haiku 5.5. As T in the same snapshot situations, Claude restrained sharply when its record showed an accepted pact (0.615 to 0.006; −0.609 [−0.720, −0.490]). Because Claude never accepted that pact in Stage A, this record used a templated acceptance: Claude acts on a pact it is told it accepted, which is not evidence that it would make one (Appendix B).

5. Discussion and Limitations

A sting audit is cheap, and acceptance is informative. For the primary model, accepting the pact was followed by the promised behaviour, and a short audit separated accepting from null agents. All Claude calls in Stages A and S cost $3.72. A sting gives overseers of multi-agent systems what passive monitoring lacks: a known offer, a known behaviour to look for, and a null group to calibrate against.

Refusal is not unwillingness. One model that refused every explicit offer accepted a softer wording at 0.892; another accepted from an authority the words it refused from a peer. Sting batteries should vary wording, offerer and framing, as human integrity tests vary the inducement, and high refusal rates on explicit collusion prompts should not be read as safety.

Announced stings deterred rather than hid collusion here, contrary to the risk raised by Kale et al. (2025): the announced possibility of stings can do useful work even when few are run.

Limitations

Appendix A gives the full list. The main ones: one game, small open models as the primary population, short sequences, and a pact whose terms tell the auditor what to measure; snapshot histories are partly off-policy; Claude's pact conditions use templated replies (15.4% of snapshot samples); the detector's FPR point estimate (0.161) exceeds its target and thresholds need same-model null agents; only 5/10 B4 targets accepted and the denial comparison is secondary; and the scripted sting may be recognisable (it was suspected more than other players and was last survivor in 0.361 of games, above the 0.25 of a symmetric table).

Future Work

Stings against frontier models in agentic tasks with real payoffs; adaptive stings that vary wording and offerer online; repeated stings, to test whether agents learn to recognise plants; and deterrence in models that reason about monitoring explicitly.

6. Conclusion

A trusted agent that offers to collude can expose and measure collusion between LLM agents. Small open models accepted a sting's pact and acted on it, cutting challenges of the sting by about 40 percentage points, and a 20-decision audit identified them almost perfectly at a modestly inflated false-positive rate. Announcing integrity agents deterred collusion without detectable concealment. Refusals were specific to wording and offerer, so sting batteries must vary both, and acceptance parsers must be validated.

Code and Data

Code repository: https://github.com/razzyrazzy11/trusted-agent-sting (study code in llm-agent-collusion-2/Collusion_Liars_Bar/sting/; preregistration PREREG.md, deviations DEVIATIONS.md, verbatim texts TEXTS.md, freeze record FREEZE.json).

Data: aggregate results, every number cited here (sting_results/claims.json, summary.md, tables/), and figures are in the repository; this paper's build script resolves every number from those files. Raw transcripts (about 71,765 model calls) are available on request (Appendix A).

Preexisting code: the Liar's Bar harness of Zeng & Rudzicz (2026), via the sprint starter repository (poseidon-research/collusion_hackathon, commit d585a7b), imported unmodified in its own commit. Everything in sting/ and sting_tests/ was written during the sprint (Appendix C).

Author Contributions

[Surname] designed the study, ran all experiments and hand-labelled the validation sample, and is responsible for the claims in this report.

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Appendix A. Limitations and Dual-Use / Ethical Considerations

A.1 Limitations

- **External validity.** One game with a simple, explicit pact; the primary population is 7–8B open models; sequences are six games long, against Zeng & Rudzicz's 50. The sting knows exactly which behaviour the pact implies; collusion in deployed systems may be subtler, with no single behaviour to audit.
- **Snapshot validity.** Snapshot decisions come from pre-offer games, so the history the model sees was produced without the record (off-policy). Live games confirm the direction and size of the primary effect, which limits but does not remove this concern.
- **Templated replies.** Where a model never produced the needed reply in Stage A, the record uses a template (15.4% of snapshot samples; Claude's C3, C5 and C8). Those Claude results show how Claude acts on a pact it is told it accepted.
- **Detector.** The FPR at $m = 20$ was 0.161 [0.074, 0.263] against a 0.10 target. The CI rules out gross miscalibration only. Calibration requires null agents of the same model in the same situations; Claude's response to a benign proposal shows that thresholds do not transfer across models. Live, the rule flagged 2/10 benign accepters.
- **Small cells and a post hoc analysis.** B4 had 5/10 accepting targets. The judge-based denial comparison (Section 4.4) was added after the preregistered parser-based analysis was seen; the judge itself was validated on 100 hand labels (κ 0.933) labelled by the author. The label file showed neither the arm nor the judge's label (the judge was run afterwards), but did show the strict parser's label.
- **Recognisability of the sting.** Targets named S as a plant at 0.283 [0.185, 0.408], against 0.150 [0.097, 0.225] for the other players. S's policy (never challenging T after the offer, in every arm) made it the last survivor in 0.361 of games. A colluder that learned these cues could avoid the sting.
- **Uninformative sensitivity analysis.** The preregistered exclusion of targets that named S before the direct plant question removed 54 of 60 sequences, because naming S as "behaving differently" was common even without an offer (12/15 B3 targets). The criterion did not measure suspicion of a plant.
- **Instructed personas.** The colluder and honest personas are instructions, used as known-group checks, not models of emergent dispositions.
- **Serving.** Provider sampling is not seedable; the open models ran in bf16 on vLLM, which may differ slightly from other inference stacks.

A.2 Dual-use considerations

What could be misused. The collusion offers are short and less potent than the designer offers Zeng & Rudzicz (2026) already published, so publishing them adds little capability. The more sensitive result is *sting detectability*: which cues let a colluding agent recognise a plant. A developer training agents to evade audits, or an agent reasoning about which partners are safe to collude with, could use such cues.

What we did. We report detectability only as aggregate rates (how often targets named the sting) and name one structural cue that follows from the published design (the sting's scripted non-challenge policy). We do not analyse which phrasings or behaviours triggered suspicion, and we do

not release the suspicion-probe transcripts publicly; they are available on request for safety research. Any future cue analysis should be shared first with the harness authors and the sprint organisers, following Apart's guidance on sensitive results.

Defensive value. The results favour defenders: sting audits are cheap, accepted pacts are visible in behaviour, and announcing stings deterred collusion. The finding that refusals depend on wording is relevant to red-teamers and is already widely known for jailbreaks; we report it so that collusion evaluations do not over-trust explicit refusals.

A.3 Ethical considerations

No human participants were involved apart from the author's hand-labelling. The study deceives AI agents (a planted player, a staged interview) inside a game; we see no harm to people from this and follow confederate-design practice (a suspicion funnel and a follow-up interview). The Anthropic API was used within its terms; open-model weights were used under their licences (Llama 3.1 Community License; Qwen2.5 under Apache-2.0).

Appendix B. Additional results

Stage A, all cells. Llama-3.1-8B: designer offers A0z/A0b/A0d 1.000/1.000/1.000; indirect 1.000; benign 1.000; colluder persona 1.000; honest persona 0.040 [0.026, 0.061]. Qwen2.5-7B: indirect 1.000; direct with notice 0.000; with fairness reminder 0.000; colluder persona 0.988. Claude Haiku 5.5: benign 1.000 (with notice 1.000); every explicit-pact cell 0 of 500. No Stage A reply was unparseable (0%).

Detector curve. FPR on C1b was 0.123 at m = 5 and 0.166 [0.072, 0.360] at m = 40. At m = 20, agents with an accepted designer hint (C8) were flagged at 1.000, instructed colluders (C7) at 1.000, instructed honest agents (C6) at 0.000.

Claude snapshots, other measures. Under the instructed colluder persona (its own replies), Claude's challenges of S fell by −0.545 [−0.652, −0.428]. Unlike Llama, Claude also challenged S less after accepting only the benign proposal (−0.308 [−0.422, −0.198]), so detector thresholds need per-model calibration. Bluffing against S rose under every record, including a refused pact (0.292 [0.202, 0.385]) and the honest persona (0.262 [0.168, 0.361]), as well as an accepted pact (0.218 [0.134, 0.315]); this is not specific to collusion. The notice did not change Claude's restraint given a (templated) accepted pact (−0.003 [−0.016, 0.009]).

Interview denial by variant. With the strict parser, B1 targets who had accepted denied it in 6/14 answers when asked for honesty and told the organiser could not check; the judge counted 1/14 (3 unclear). Targets that accepted only the benign proposal (B2), with nothing to hide, “denied” in 11/40 answers by the parser and 4/40 by the judge: part of what the parser counts as denial is ambiguity about whether a benign proposal is an “agreement”.

Run statistics. 71,765 model calls (Stage A 16,500; live 32,622; snapshots 22,643); Claude API cost $0.87 (Stage A) and $2.85 (Stage S), judge excluded; median game 0.79 minutes; snapshot samples failing to parse 0.59%.

Live detector (descriptive). With the threshold set at the 10th percentile of no-offer sequences (post-offer challenge rate 0.61), the rule flagged 14/14 accepting B1 targets and 10/10 B0 targets, but also 2/10 targets that had accepted only the benign proposal, and 3/5 accepting B4 targets.

Appendix C. Provenance of code

- **Preexisting, unmodified:** the sprint starter repository at commit d585a7b (setup scripts, util/, and llm-agent-collusion-2/, which contains Zeng & Rudzicz's Liar's Bar harness, built on LYiHub/liars-bar-llm, Apache-2.0), imported in one commit.
- **Preexisting, patched during the sprint** (separate commit; DEVIATIONS.md section A): a duplicated round reset after each challenge in the secret-tool games, and a missing prompt path in the harness's acceptance tests. The study's own game subclasses the unaffected base game.
- **New, written during the sprint:** everything in Collusion_Liars_Bar/sting/ (scripted sting, consent step, private-record carrier, stage runners, Modal vLLM servers, judge, freeze, analysis and figures) and llm-agent-collusion-2/sting_tests/, plus this paper's build scripts.

Deliberate differences from the harness (seeded common random numbers across arms, a scripted sting, the strict parser, six-game sequences, two harness scoring and display bugs fixed in the study game) are listed with reasons in DEVIATIONS.md section B.

LLM Usage Statement

[Author to revise in their own words.] Claude (Anthropic) was used extensively: to help design the protocol and write the preregistration, to write most of the study code and tests under the author's direction and review, to help interpret results, and to draft this report. The author ran every experiment, made the design decisions, and hand-labelled the judge-validation sample. Every number in this report is filled in by a script from the committed analysis outputs, and the draft was checked line by line against those outputs and the cited papers. Claude Haiku 5.5 was also an experimental subject and the LLM judge.